a succession of emissaries to Bahadur Shah to convince him of the wisdom in submitting to the Padshah. But Bahadur Shah sent unsatisfactory gifts of ‘four inferior elephants’ and did not come from the Asirgarh fortress in person to pay obeisance.

Abu’l Fazl was sent out to guard the frontiers of Khandesh by setting up military posts throughout the kingdom. Soon all of Khandesh, apart from the fort of Asirgarh, was Mughal territory. Abu’l Fazl was accompanied in his campaign by his son, Abdur Rahman, and his brother, Abu’l Barkat. During his Deccan campaigns, Abu’l Fazl seemed to grow into the full extent of his expansive, generous, and surprisingly worldly nature. It had always been his habit, on the day of the Islamic new year, to make a detailed inventory of his household items and to give away all his clothes to his servants, apart from his payjamas which he had burnt in his presence. Now, in the Deccan, ‘his arrangements and establishments’, wrote the author of the *Maasir ul-Umara*, ‘were beyond anything that could be imagined’. He had a large tent pitched in which was a divan for the shaikh, and every day 1,000 plates of food were cooked and distributed among the officers. Outside the tent was a canopy, within which khichdi was cooked all day long for any soldier or hungry person who presented themselves. Abu’l Fazl himself, we are told, ‘had a wonderful appetite’, with an impressive daily intake of almost 20 kilograms of food, not including water and broth. His son, Abdur Rahman, waited upon his father while he ate, while the superintendent of his kitchen stood by. Whichever dish Abu’l Fazl served himself from a second time would be cooked again the following day. If any dish was not to his liking, he wordlessly passed it along to Abdur Rahman, who would then taste it and upbraid the cook accordingly. While Abu’l Fazl’s arrangements were particularly grand, they were not exceptional. All the prominent Mughal mansabdars prided themselves on their establishments when they were travelling to war. Islam Khan Chishti, a foster brother of Salim and Subedar of Bengal, kept an austere diet of millet, vegetables, spinach, and dry rice, but ordered for his soldiers the preparation of 1,000 trays of the best quality food daily. Many employed a variety of cooks—Persian, Turani, Kashmiri, and European, with Brahmins employed to cook separately for the Hindu soldiers. Foot soldiers, naturally, often made do with a drastically simpler diet, as noted by a later traveller:

> The horseman as well as the infantry soldier supports himself with a little flour kneaded with water and black sugar, of which they make